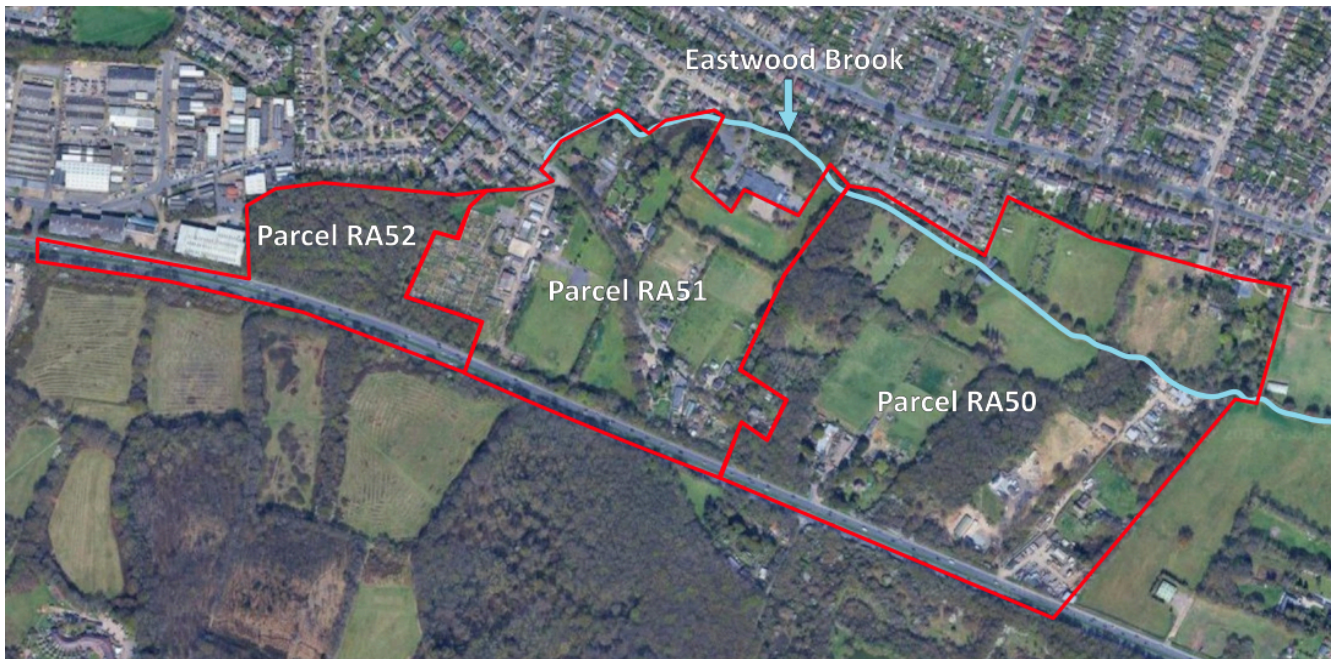


Wyburns Area Residents Group - Grey Belt Objection



Introduction

Rochford District Council is preparing a Local Plan which will set out where new homes will be built in order to meet government housing targets.

In order to make it easier to meet their targets, the government has changed planning rules so that areas of Green Belt can be reclassified as Grey Belt which can make the land an option for development.

To assess the Green Belt, Rochford District Council commissioned a report from LUC (Land Use Consultants). In July 2026 LUC published their draft report which identified land in and around Daws Heath Road and Lower Wyburns Farm (parcels RA50, RA51 & RA52) as potential Grey Belt.

When producing their report, LUC used the following to rate each of the parcels above:

Purpose A - Preventing the unrestricted spread of large built-up areas.

Purpose B - Preventing neighbouring towns and settlements from merging together.

Purpose C - Safeguarding the countryside from encroachment.

Purpose D - Preserving the setting and special character of historic towns.

Purpose E - Supporting urban regeneration (all Green Belt land is considered to contribute equally to this purpose).

LUC Assessment			
	RA50	RA51	RA52
Purpose A	Moderate	Moderate	Moderate
Purpose B	Weak/No	Weak/No	Weak/No
Purpose C	Moderate	Moderate	Strong
Purpose D	Weak/No	Weak/No	Weak/No
Purpose E	Equal	Equal	Equal
Grey Belt	Yes	Yes	Yes

Our Evidence

The following evidence, which we believe has been overlooked or understated in the LUC report, suggests that the assessment relies heavily on Google Maps aerial imagery, with little or no evidence of on-site surveys or local knowledge.

Eastwood Brook

The map above shows Eastwood Brook in blue. It is an Environment Agency Main River and, together with its established vegetation, forms part of a landscape boundary separating the urban edge from open countryside.

LUC own guidelines state

3.57 Any breaching of a significant existing physical feature, or a significant combination of adjacent physical features, that currently serve to restrict and contain the existing large built-up area, would also form an incongruous pattern of development. Examples of this sort of step-change in settlement form would be development crossing a major retaining and containing road, railway or river, or extending out from a valley onto a hilltop into open Green Belt land that does not relate well to existing development.

Despite this, LUC does not refer to Eastwood Brook in its report.

We believe this creates a physical border spanning RA50, RA51 & RA52 which prevents the unrestricted spread of large built-up areas.

We believe this justifies a **Strong rating for Purpose A** with reference to RA50, RA51 & RA52

The A127 boundary

The report frequently proposes the A127, along with vegetation, as a key reason why RA50, RA51 and RA52 are considered to have Grey Belt potential, it treats the A127 as a strong, permanent boundary that would contain any development and maintains separation from Hadleigh to the south.

Although the A127 and associated vegetation are important containment features it should not be relied upon alone, it does not demonstrate that RA50, RA51 and RA52 fail to perform Green Belt functions.

If Green Belt status is removed and developments are built within close proximity of the A127 this could limit any A127 upgrades that may be required in the future as increases in traffic over time are inevitable.

A127 should not degrade a **Moderate rating for Purpose B** with reference to RA50, RA51 & RA52

REFUSED PLANNING PERMISSION 25/00950/FUL

In July 2026, after the national Grey Belt concept had been introduced, Rochford District Council refused development within RA51 on the basis of substantial harm to Green Belt openness and attached substantial weight to the Green Belt function of the site.

This demonstrates that the site continues to perform an important Green Belt role and remains predominantly open countryside.

The decision therefore raises questions as to whether the parcel's contribution to Green Belt purposes, particularly Purpose A (checking urban sprawl) and Purpose C (safeguarding the countryside from encroachment), has been fully reflected in the Grey Belt assessment by LUC.

We believe this justifies a **Strong rating for Purpose A & Purpose C** with reference to RA51

RA51 Urbanising Influence

LUC states that the land is generally open but contains some urbanising land uses and activities in this parcel. This includes playing fields associated with Wyburns Primary School, allotments and scattered residential dwellings. It also states 'some notable areas of open land'.

What the report does not quote is any figures regarding how much of the parcel remains open land:

Allotments 6.9%

Playing Fields 7.5%

Buildings 4.8%

We believe that the level of urbanisation within parcel RA51 has been overstated. Only a site visit can fully demonstrate how the openness, mature trees and ancient hedgerows create a strong connection to the surrounding countryside and provide a considerable contrast with urban Rayleigh.

We believe this could justify a **Strong rating for Purpose C** with reference to RA51

Emerging Historical Evidence

LUC accepts that RA50 and RA51 form part of the setting of historic Rayleigh but assigns both parcels a Weak/No contribution to Purpose D, basis that they contain none of the features contributing to its setting or special character.

However, new evidence now identifies a much wider historic landscape including Eastwood Brook, the Essex Historic Environment Record evidence for Rayleigh Medieval Deer Park, historic routes and boundaries, long-standing farmstead relationships, surviving earthworks and basin landforms, and documentary evidence for medieval and later park, water, fishery, milling and estate organisation around Rayleigh and Eastwood.

Additional evidence continues to emerge, and the site is scheduled to be reviewed by archaeologists and historical organisations. The most important point is that there is already sufficient evidence of surviving historic landscape relationships to challenge the categorical finding that the parcels contain none of the features contributing to the setting and special character of historic Rayleigh.

We believe this could justify a **Strong rating for Purpose D** with reference to RA50, RA51

Wyburns Area Residence Assessment			
	RA50	RA51	RA52
Purpose A	Strong	Strong	Strong
Purpose B	Moderate	Moderate	Moderate
Purpose C	Moderate	Strong	Strong
Purpose D	Weak/No	Possible Strong	Possible Strong
Purpose E	Equal	Equal	Equal
Grey Belt	No	No	No

Conclusion

Based on the evidence set out above, we believe that parcels RA50, RA51 and RA52 make a significantly stronger contribution to Green Belt purposes than is reflected in the draft LUC assessment. In particular, the role of Eastwood Brook as a defining physical boundary, the continued openness of the land, the recent refusal of development within RA51, and emerging historic landscape evidence support the conclusion that these parcels should not be classified as Grey Belt. We therefore request that Rochford District Council reconsider the assessment and retain the Green Belt status of these parcels within the emerging Local Plan.